

MAMATA CLAIMS THE STOPPAGES WERE WITHDRAWN WITHOUT HER MINISTRY'S CONSENT

PATNA | NO STOPPING THEM

When Eastern Railways suddenly withdrew 33 stoppage halts from Bihar immediately after Lalu Prasad Yadav was replaced at the ministry, an anti-Bihar conspiracy was instantly suspected. An irate mob of mischief-mongers set afire eight bogies of two passenger trains at Patna's Khusrupur station, presumably protesting on behalf of deprived passengers. The new Railways Minister Mamata Banerjee has ordered a probe, insisting that she is not in favour of withdrawing any facility and stating that this had been done without her ministry's consent. Though the order seeking withdrawal of the stoppages was already suspended, perhaps it was not communicated in time. The stoppages were later restored. The order was also communicated to station masters last Sunday.

by Amitabh Srivastava

AJAY KUMAR



A PASSENGER TRAIN ON FIRE IN BIHAR

KOLKATA | Cyclone Trail

Nine years ago, a famous photograph of Chief Minister Buddhadeb Bhattacharya riding a rickshaw in a remote village ravaged by dacoits had won him brownie points. Since then, his public relations skills had hit an all-time low, culminating in the disaster that was Elections 2009. But the man is now keen to re-polish those PR skills. On a recent visit to the Cyclone Aila-affected areas in Sunderbans, a sagely 'Buddha' sat in a school courtyard in Gosaba, an Aila-affected village, along with the local block development officer (BDO). As the man rediscovered his masses, the BDO was on standby, furiously taking notes as he was apparently expected to provide solutions to a range of rural woes. *by Abhijit Dasgupta*

HAS A POOR SHOW IN THE LOK SABHA ELECTIONS COMPELLED BUDDHADEB BHATTACHARYA TO FALL BACK ON HIS FAMED PR SKILLS?

MUMBAI | BEST Bet

Mumbai's BEST buses are all set to go tech-friendly. In the next few months, over 4,000 red state-run buses will be fitted with bluetooth-enabled services. These will give details on the routes the bus will cover, the next stop and the time it will take to reach the final destination, depending on traffic. "The service would be of help to nearly 50 lakh commuters," says Dilip Patel, BEST chairman. The proposal is expected to be tabled within the next month and once passed, the humble BEST bus can aspire to become the common man's Batmobile. *by Aditi Pal*

MUMBAI | Khaki Demand

PATKAR



SUMEEET INDER SINGH

Activist Medha Patkar has moved a contempt petition against the Maharashtra Government for failing to bring about police reforms. This comes in response to the observations made by the Ram Pradhan panel, which probed the 26/11 attacks on Mumbai. Allegedly giving the police a clean chit, the Pradhan Committee report said that 'no police force can deal with a warlike situation'. In 2006, the Supreme Court directed all states to bring about reforms that involved the setting up of a state security commission, ensuring proper selection and separating investigation for law and order. While the diktat was reiterated in 2007, Maharashtra failed to bring about any of these changes. *by Swati Mathur*